



You can set passwords for new users, or let Google auto-generate one

than the default hour, you just have to drag the lower end of the event box.

You can share calendars with each other, and know when members of your team are free or busy—this lets you plan activities around everyone's schedule. You can also synchronise your Google calendar with Outlook (using third-party software), and even with your Blackberry.

Docs

Google Docs is another interesting tool that's a part of Google Apps. With Google Docs, you can do away with the Office suite altogether. You and your team can collaborate on documents, spreadsheets and presentations all in one go! Google Docs offers you the option to share and publish your documents in to a unique URL. That apart, you can save it to a host of other formats too. This is of immense help to those people who are always on the move. They can start work while away from their workspace, without worrying about any data being lost. To use Google Docs, visit <http://docs.your-domain.com>. Once here, you can click on the New tab to the left. Of the options for Document, Spreadsheet or Presentation, choose any depending on your requirement. Once you start typing, Google Docs continuously saves your document as and when changes are made.

E-mail

In its basic version, Google Apps provides 6 GB of storage per user—quite like a personal Gmail account. The URL for your e-mail will be <http://mail.your-domain.com>. In addition, Google also monitors abuse@yourdomain.com and postmaster@yourdomain.com to report spam, abuse and other technical issues. Configuring the email addresses of your employees to Google Apps doesn't require more than couple of minutes. There are two major steps involved in setting up your new mail service. First, you need to create new user accounts. Second, set up the email delivery.

To switch your domain to use Google Mail, you'll need to change your MX records—you can do this from the administration page of your hosting provider. You can find instructions specific to your provider here: <http://www.google.com/support/a/bin/answer.py?answer=87084>. It takes around

two days for MX records to get updated—to avoid losing e-mails during this time, first create all the e-mail accounts you need, and only then change the MX records.

You can upload the details of existing e-mail accounts in bulk using the CSV format—username,userid,password. Log in to the control panel and go to Advanced tools. To upload the list in bulk, go to User Accounts Bulk Update. Upload the CSV file, and you're done. Once you've created the same user accounts in your control panel as you have in your existing domain, you won't lose any new mail.

Another interesting feature that Google Apps provides is email reforwarding. For example, say you have an employee named John in your organisation, and his email address is john.smith@your-domain.com. If someone sends an e-mail to johnsmith@your-domain.com, you can set it up so that the e-mail reaches a "catch all" account like error@your-domain.com.

Chat

At times, teams in your organisation may reside at remote locations or even client bases, making communication back and forth rather tedious and expensive. To reduce these ancillary costs, Google Talk is a viable option. With Google Apps, you can configure Google Talk within the users in your organisation. To control the use of Google Talk, go to the dashboard and click Chat—Google Apps gives you the option to warn your users when they chat with users outside your domain. You can use this feature to ensure no sensitive information gets out, and that your employees aren't wasting their time chatting with friends.

Wrapping Up

You get to take charge of all your online needs, without the hassles a typical system administrator faces. Google does all the dirty work for you, while you can focus on improved productivity and business related issues. Apart from this, if the Docs application is optimally used, you can drive the running costs to rock bottom by doing away with the office suite completely. With large corporate houses also showing interest in Google Apps, this is one upcoming trend. ■

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